

Intercession of the Saints

By Dn Yonnas · Apologetics · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

Why the Ethiopian Orthodox Church asks for the prayers of the Holy Virgin Mary, the angels, and the saints. The lesson distinguishes Christ's unique propitiatory mediation from the intercessory prayer God Himself commands, walks through the biblical proofs (Abraham, Job, Moses), and answers the most common objections with Scripture.

Lesson Objectives

- Distinguish Christ's propitiatory advocacy from the intercessory prayer of the righteous
- Present the Old and New Testament evidence that God asks for and honors intercession
- Answer the objection 'there is one Mediator' faithfully and charitably

Key Bible Verses

1 Timothy 2:5 — one Mediator in the propitiatory sense: Christ alone paid for sin

Job 42:7–8 — "my servant Job shall pray for you, for him I will accept"

Romans 15:30 — St. Paul asks the living faithful to strive with him in prayer

Main Teaching Points

- Christ alone is the propitiation for our sins — no saint shares in that
- God commanded Abimelech to seek Abraham's prayer and Job's friends to seek Job's
- Moses' intercession turned away wrath from Israel (Exodus 32)
- Death does not end this honor: God spares for David's sake long after David's repose
- The saints in heaven know more, not less — their knowledge is perfected (1 Cor 13:12)
- We do not worship the saints; we ask their prayers, as we ask our friends on earth

Key Terms

- **Intercession** — Prayer offered on behalf of another — commanded and honored by God throughout Scripture.
- **Propitiation** — The payment for sin. Christ alone is the propitiation for our sins (1 John 2:1–2).
- **Theosis** — Becoming by grace what God is by nature — the goal of salvation, in which the saints already shine.
- **Mediator** — In the unique propitiatory sense, Christ alone; in the sense of praying for others, all the righteous.

Discussion & Reflection

- If you ask a friend to pray for you, why would you not ask a saint who stands before God?
- How does God honoring His saints actually glorify God Himself?
- How would you explain intercession gently to a Protestant friend?

Glory be to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, one God. Amen.